# Appendix: Badges, Levels and Transition

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## Summary

This appendix sets the career levels, how badges are earned and kept, and how current staff move into the new model between January and March 2027. Where other documents differ, this appendix takes precedence.

**What changes:**

- **Fifteen badges in three families.** Five C (core) badges, five B (specialist) badges and five A (advanced) badges. No badge requires an outside certification.
- **Six levels.** L0 Junior RCM Specialist for new hires, L1 and L2 earned automatically once the badges are held, and L3, L4 and L5 earned through a leveling test once the badges are held. L5 Principal is the leadership level for team leads, managers and the Senior Manager.
- **Annual top 10%.** Every December the top 10% of each level earn any badges of their level they are missing, and an L2 in the top 10% moves up to L3 without a test.
- **Test windows.** Members can enrol in a test window every quarter to earn badges or sit a leveling test, including by testing out on work they already do.
- **Keeping badges.** Every 6 months, KPIs decide which badges each member keeps. Losing 25% of badges means probation and coaching, and losing 50% means termination. Consequences start with the December 2027 review.
- **Bridge night rota.** Any L2, L3 or L4 member holding B2 can opt in, for a quarterly bonus of $300–3,000.
- **Transition.** The top 10% of each current role earn their role badges without tests. The bottom 10% restart at L1 through the Academy. Everyone else has 3 months to pass their role tests.

**Pay:** no one's pay goes down, including anyone who moves down a level. Anyone who moves up a level gets a guaranteed raise.

## The six levels

Level is set by the badges a member holds and their results. Former title plays no part.

| Level | Title | Badges required | How it is earned |
|---|---|---|---|
| L0 | Junior RCM Specialist | None | On hire |
| L1 | RCM Specialist I | All 5 C badges | Automatically, at the next quarterly window after the badges are held |
| L2 | RCM Specialist II | All 5 C + B1 or B2 + 2 of B3, B4 and B5 | Automatically, at the next quarterly window after the badges are held |
| L3 | Senior Specialist I | All 5 C + all 5 B + at least 1 A | L3 leveling test, once the badges are held |
| L4 | Senior Specialist II | All 5 C + all 5 B + at least 3 A | L4 leveling test, once the badges are held |
| L5 | Principal (Leadership) | All 5 C + all 5 B + at least 4 A | L5 leveling test, once the badges are held, plus a team lead or manager post |

**The badges:**

| Family | Badge | Covers |
|---|---|---|
| C · Core | C1 Attaching Docs | Attaching and indexing EOBs, remits, records and payer letters to the right account |
| C · Core | C2 Claim Follow-up | Receipt confirmation, status follow-up, next-action dates, resubmissions |
| C · Core | C3 Appeal | Code and money appeals, non-NSA denials, the appeal letter library |
| C · Core | C4 Payment Posting | ERA exceptions, manual posting, IDR awards, refunds, closure |
| C · Core | C5 Medical-Necessity Report | Report from the approved prompt library, checked against the chart |

| Family | Badge | Covers |
|---|---|---|
| B · Specialist | B1 Coding | ER E/M levels 99281–99285, procedures, ICD-10, modifiers, scrubbing |
| B · Specialist | B2 IDR Process Workflow | NSA eligibility, Open Negotiation, initiation, batching, the IDR Prep Studio, deadlines |
| B · Specialist | B3 MVA and WComp Negotiation & Process | Order of coverage, workers' comp process, liens, adjuster negotiation |
| B · Specialist | B4 Payer Strategy | Playbooks for 1–2 payers: QPA patterns, offer ranges, escalation contacts |
| B · Specialist | B5 Payer Outreach | Payer calls, portals, provider-relations contacts, escalation paths |
| A · Advanced | A1 Reporting and Analysis | Reports, dashboards and monthly trend analysis from ClickUp and eCW |
| A · Advanced | A2 IDR Strategy | Offer setting, IDR entity selection, packet writing, outcome review |
| A · Advanced | A3 Medical Terminology | Clinical terms and complex charts, in support of coding, appeals and reports |
| A · Advanced | A4 Billing Strategy | Payer billing rules, timely filing, denial prevention, upstream fixes |
| A · Advanced | A5 Innovation | Automations, AI prompts and process improvements with measured results |

Course hours, supervised production, assessments and pass marks for each badge are in the badge competency matrix and the Training Academy curriculum.

**Role at each level:**

- **L3 Senior Specialist I:** the team's expert on a payer portfolio, a peer QA reviewer and mentor, and eligible for team lead.
- **L4 Senior Specialist II:** leads a specialty group, sits on Badge Panels as an assessor and teaches in the Academy. These are the duties of the old L4 Principal.

**Leveling tests and the annual top 10%:**

- **Leveling tests (L3, L4, L5):** held in the quarterly test windows. A case-based exam across the level's badges, plus a review of the last 6 months: QA of 95% or higher for L3, 97% or higher for L4 and L5, and zero missed deadlines.
- **Team Lead (L5):** the L5 leveling test plus a coaching assessment, and an internally posted team lead seat.
- **Manager (L5):** the L5 leveling test plus a leadership assessment, and an internally posted manager seat.
- **Annual top 10%:** every December, members are ranked within their level on the year's KPIs. The top 10% earn any badges of their current level they don't yet hold. An L2 in the top 10% moves up to L3 without the leveling test, and earns any missing L3 badges within the next 12 months while keeping the level.

Leaders keep their badges and their QA reviews.

## Earning badges: quarterly test windows

Badges are earned in four test windows a year, so every member knows when they can certify and can plan for it.

| Window | Enrolment closes | Results published |
|---|---|---|
| Last two weeks of March | 4 weeks before | Within 10 business days |
| Last two weeks of June | 4 weeks before | Within 10 business days |
| Last two weeks of September | 4 weeks before | Within 10 business days |
| Last two weeks of December | 4 weeks before | Within 10 business days |

**What each window offers:**

- The assessment for every C, B and A badge, scored by a Badge Panel: a QA reviewer plus 2 assessors (L4s or team leads) from other teams.
- The L3, L4 and L5 leveling tests, for members who hold the level's badges.
- The full skill assessment, which shows a member's current level and training needs across all 15 badges.

**Two ways to earn a badge:**

1. **Course route:** for new hires and anyone new to the task. Academy module, then supervised production, then the window assessment.

2. **Test-out route:** for members who already do the work. Enrol directly in the window assessment. A pass is followed by 10 supervised cases before ClickUp starts routing that work.

A failed assessment can be retaken in the next window, after targeted practice agreed with the team lead.

## Keeping badges: the semiannual review

Every June 30 and December 31, each member's KPIs for the half-year decide which badges they keep. The June 2027 review is for coaching only, and consequences start with the December 2027 review.

**The review looks at:** QA by badge, critical errors, work units against target, and Net Recovery against the member's tier.

**A badge is lost when, over the half-year, any of these is true:**

- Its QA is below the badge's keep threshold.
- It has 2 or more critical errors.
- It was suspended and not re-earned by the review.

**Consequences** are counted against the badges held at the start of the half-year, rounded up to whole badges:

| Level | Badges held | Probation and coaching (25% or more lost) | Termination (50% or more lost) |
|---|---|---|---|
| L1 | 5 | 2 lost | 3 lost |
| L2 | 8 | 2 lost | 4 lost |
| L3 | 11 | 3 lost | 6 lost |
| L4 | 13 | 4 lost | 7 lost |
| L5 | 14 | 4 lost | 7 lost |

Members holding more badges than their level needs count all the badges they hold at the start of the half-year.

- **Probation and coaching (90 days):** a written plan, 100% review of the affected work, weekly check-ins with the team lead, and a re-test in the next window.

- **Termination:** handled through the HR process, with documented reviews and one appeal. The rule is subject to HR and legal review under Lebanese labor law before it is published.
- **Level:** when a member no longer holds the badges their level needs, the level is reset at the next quarterly window, and pay protection applies.

Between reviews, the monthly QA rules still apply. One review below the keep threshold triggers a coaching plan. Two reviews in a row suspend the badge until it is re-earned.

## Pay principles

Moving down a level never cuts pay, and moving up a level always raises it.

- **Pay protection:** no one's base pay goes down when their level changes.
- **A raise on every move up:** every move up a level comes with a pay raise, effective on the first day of the next month.

| Move | How |
|---|---|
| L0 → L1 | Automatic once all 5 C badges are held |
| L1 → L2 | Automatic once the L2 badges are held |
| L2 → L3 | L3 leveling test, or the annual top 10% |
| L3 → L4 | L4 leveling test |
| L3 or L4 → Team Lead (L5) | L5 leveling test, coaching assessment, internal posting |
| Team Lead or L4 → Manager (L5) | L5 leveling test, leadership assessment, internal posting |

There is no minimum time in a level. Moves take effect on the first day of the month after the window.

## Bridge night rota

The bridge shift is no longer limited to 2 team leads. Any L2, L3 or L4 member holding B2 can opt in, and a fixed quarterly pool is shared by everyone on the rota.

**The shift:** 16:00–24:00 Beirut, Monday to Friday, which is 08:00–16:00 US Central. Two members work each night, and at least one of them holds A2 and acts as night lead. That is 10 member-nights a week and 130 a quarter. The rota reports to the Onshore–Offshore Liaison portfolio owner, who sets it each quarter from the opt-ins.

**Duties:** check the tickets due that day, answer the US desk within 15 minutes, fix rejected tickets the same US day, and post the nightly handover log.

**Rota options:**

- **10 members:** each works 1 night a week, 13 nights a quarter.
- **20 members:** each works 1 night every other week, 6–7 nights a quarter.
- **Any size in between** also works.

**Quarterly bonus:** a fixed pool of $30,000 a quarter is shared equally by the rota, within $300–3,000 per member. The fewer members, the more nights each works and the higher each share. Every rota size pays about $230 per night worked.

| Members on the rota | Nights each per quarter | Bonus per member per quarter |
|---|---|---|
| 10 | 13 | $3,000 |
| 15 | 8–9 | $2,000 |
| 20 | 6–7 | $1,500 |
| 30 | 4–5 | $1,000 |
| 50 | 2–3 | $600 |
| 100 | 1–2 | $300 |

**Conditions:**

- Members get their full share when the rota meets its targets: 98% first-pass tickets, US desk questions answered within 15 minutes, and no deadline missed because of a ticket.
- Members must work all their assigned nights; swaps are allowed. Missed nights reduce the share pro rata.
- Transport home after the shift is covered.

**Cost:** up to $120,000 a year. This replaces the earlier $6,000 a year for 2 team leads.

# Transition period, January–March 2027

Current staff move into the new levels in one quarter, based on this year's results and a short round of tests. Levels take effect on April 1, 2027.

**Starting point:** every member starts at the default level for their current role.

| Current role | Default level | Role badges |
|---|---|---|
| Senior (any specialty) | L3 Senior Specialist I | The role badges of their specialty |
| Negotiator | L2 RCM Specialist II | C2, C5, B2, B5, A2 |
| Coder | L2 RCM Specialist II | C1, C5, B1, A3 |
| Biller | L2 RCM Specialist II | C1, C2, C3, C4, B5; plus B3 for those doing MVA or workers' comp |
| Team Lead | L5 Team Lead | The role badges of their former specialty |
| Manager | L5 Manager | The role badges of their former specialty |

**Three groups, ranked within each role on 2026 KPIs:**

| Group | What happens | Level on April 1, 2027 |
|---|---|---|
| Top 10% | Earn their role badges automatically, with no tests and no skill assessment | Confirmed at the default level |
| Middle 80% | Optional full skill assessment in January; then 3 months to pass the tests for their role badges in the February or March window | Pass: default level confirmed. Fail: one level down (Senior to L2; Negotiator, Coder or Biller to L1). Pass the next level's leveling test: one level up (for example, a Biller to L3) |
| Bottom 10% | Enrolled in the Academy automatically and placed at L1 | L1; they move back to L2 automatically once they hold the L2 badges |

**Steps:**

1. **December 2026:** the committee ranks every member within their current role and publishes the top 10% and bottom 10% lists.
2. **January 4, 2027:** default levels are set; the top 10% receive their role badges; the bottom 10% join the Academy at L1.
3. **January 2027:** optional full skill assessment for the middle 80%.
4. **February and March 2027:** test windows for role badges and leveling tests.
5. **March 31, 2027:** the testing period closes.
6. **April 1, 2027:** levels take effect, and raises for anyone moving up start the same day.
7. **By December 31, 2027:** everyone earns any badges still missing for their confirmed level through cross-training; the level is held provisionally until then. Current team leads and managers complete the L5 badge set by the same date, with Academy support.
8. **June 2027:** first semiannual review, for coaching only.
9. **December 2027:** first semiannual review with consequences, and the first annual top-10% ranking.

**Pay during the transition:**

- No one's pay goes down, including members moved down a level or into the Academy.
- Anyone moved up a level gets a guaranteed raise from April 1, 2027.

**Our commitment:** no one loses their job or pay because of the restructure. From December 2027, everyone is held to the same badge and performance standards.

## Open points

- [ ] **HR and legal:** review the 50% badge-loss termination rule, and the probation process, under Lebanese labor law before the policy is published.
- [ ] **Director:** confirm the $30,000 quarterly bridge pool ($120,000 a year), or set a different pool. The per-member range of $300–3,000 scales with it.
- [ ] **Director:** confirm that current team leads and managers have until December 31, 2027 to complete the L5 badge set.
- [ ] **Academy Committee:** publish the 2026 KPI ranking method per role before December, so the top and bottom 10% lists can be checked.